George was more worried still, though in his case the anxiety was professional, for this was the man he had just chosen to take over the command of the army in Afghanistan. His appointment was to be announced after the departure of Sir Willoughby Cotton; General Nott, whom Auckland regarded as chippy and difficult and far from a gentleman, was to be passed over yet again; but, wrote Auckland, he 'had only himself to blame'. Nott, in turn, had all his fears about Lord Auckland's judgement and class prejudices confirmed when he discovered he would be superseded by 'the most incompetent soldier that was to be found among all the officers of requisite rank'.

As Nott was all too aware, Elphinstone's failings were not merely medical. Like many Queen's officers of his generation, he had not seen action since he commanded the 33rd Foot at Waterloo more than twenty-five years previously, and after years on half-pay had returned to active service only in 1837, at the age of fifty-five, in order to pay off his growing debts. His patron, and the man responsible for sending him to India, was Fitzroy Somerset, Lord Raglan, later famous for ordering the suicidal Charge of the Light Brigade.[4] Elphinstone had no knowledge of or interest in the world into which Raglan had just pitched him. 'He hates being here,' noted Emily, 'wretched because nobody understands his London topics, or knows his London people, and he revels in a long letter from Lord W[ellington] . . . He cannot, of course, speak a word of Hindoostanee, and neither can his aide-de-camp: "We can never make the bearers understand us[," he complained.] "I have a negro who speaks English, but I could not bring him [up the country]." He can hardly have picked up a woolly black negro who speaks Hindoostanee. I suppose he means a Native.'[5]

Despite having seen that Elphinstone was more or less an invalid and had no sympathy for India or the Indian sepoys he would have to lead, it did not seem to have occurred to Lord Auckland to question or cancel his friend's command. Instead, he wrote warmly to him throughout the year and when his appointment was finally confirmed in December 1840, shortly after Dost Mohammad's surrender, confided to him his worries about the occupation. 'Though I am impatient gradually to withdraw our regular troops from that country,' he wrote, 'I feel that, before we can do so, the new dynasty must be more strongly confirmed than it yet has been in power, and that there must be better security than is yet established.'[6]